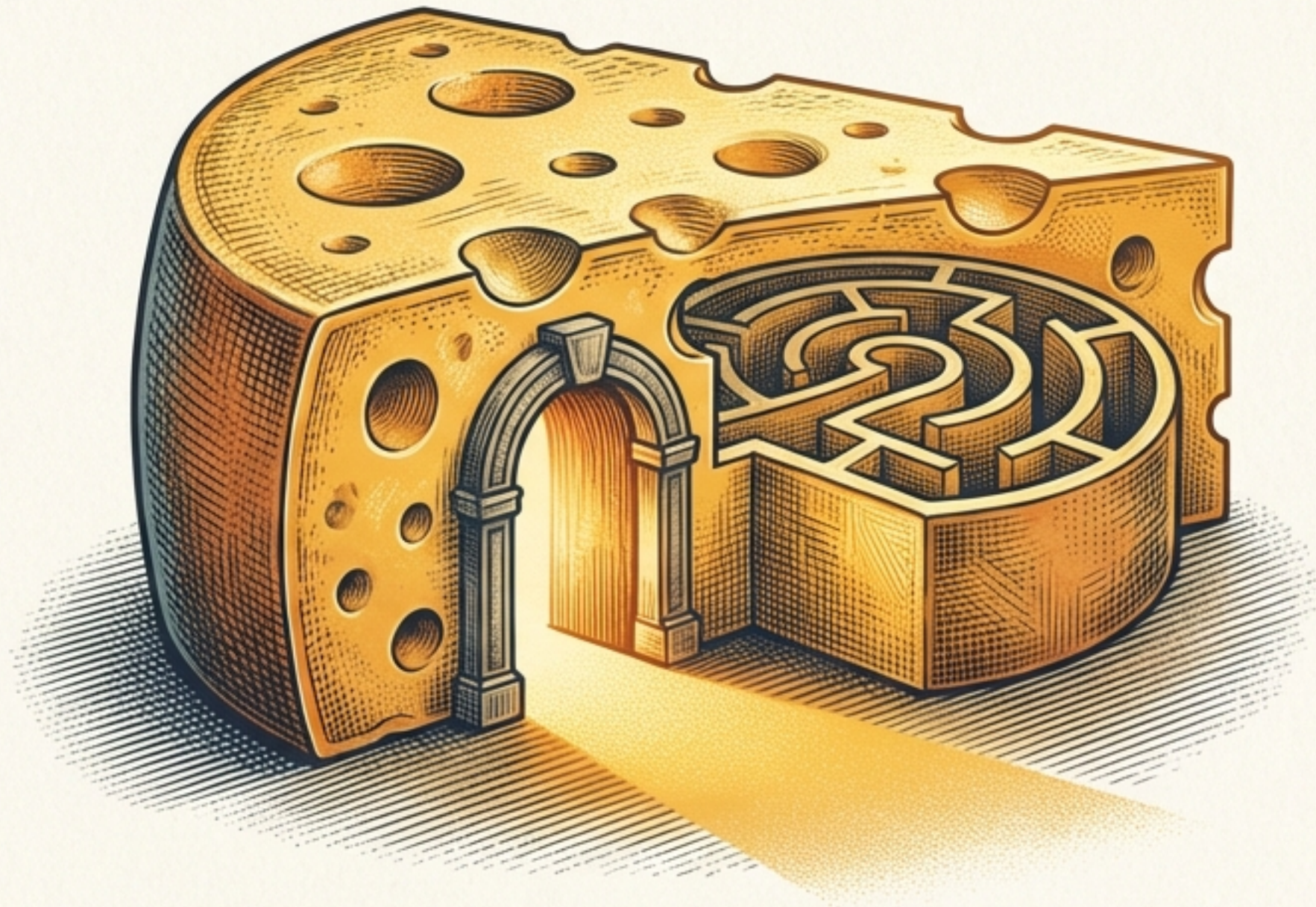


# An A-Mazing Way to Deal with Change

Understanding the Instincts and Emotions that Drive Adaptation



Based on the insights of Spencer Johnson, M.D.



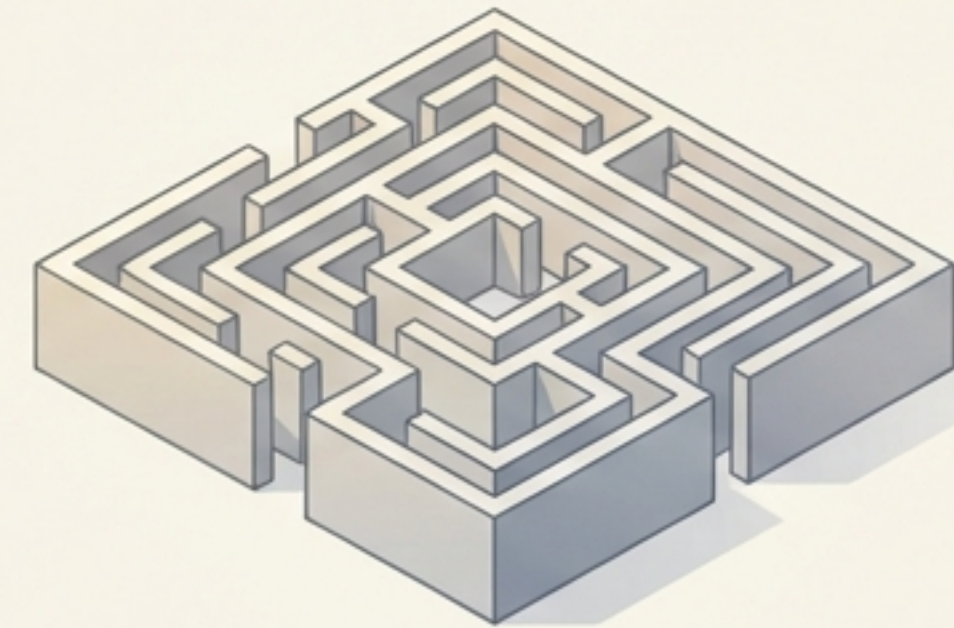
# “The Metaphor of the Maze” in Playfair Display

The story is a psychological mirror. To understand it, we must first define the symbols:



## The Cheese in Playfair Display

A metaphor for what we want to have in life—a job, a relationship, money, spiritual peace, or organizational success. We pursue it because we believe it brings happiness.



## The Maze in Playfair Display

Where you spend time looking for what you want—the organization you work in, the community you live in, or the market you operate within.



# The Four Parts of All of Us

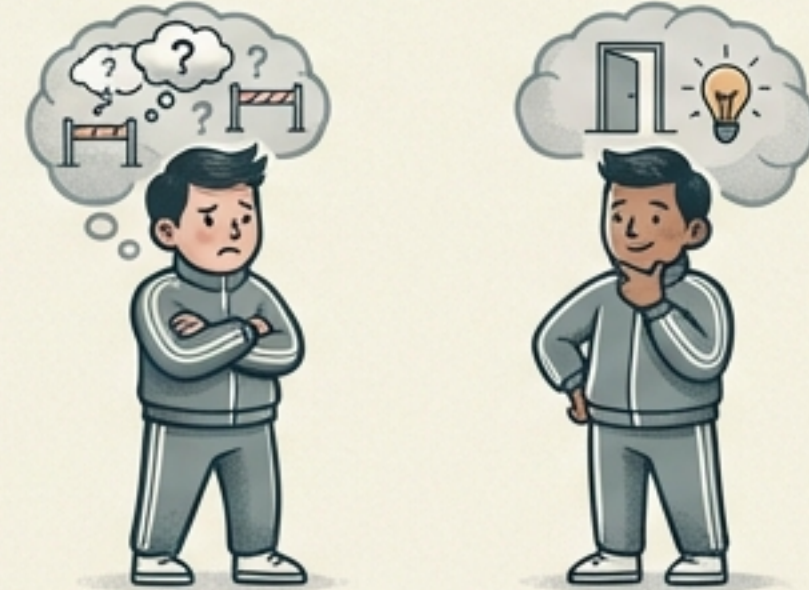
## The Simple Instinct



**Sniff:** Anticipates change early.  
**Scurry:** Races into action immediately.

Trial-and-error method. Action-oriented.

## The Complex Emotion



**Hem:** Denies and resists change out of fear.  
**Haw:** Learns to adapt when he sees the benefit.

Complex brains. Beliefs and emotions cloud judgment.

**Key Insight:** Regardless of our role, we all have these four characters living inside us.



# The Comfort Trap at Cheese Station C



## Ownership:

They moved their homes closer to the source.

## Arrogance:

Success bred a sense of entitlement.

## Assumption:

They assumed the cheese would be there forever.



# The Disruption

One morning, the cheese was gone.



**Reaction:** Immediate. Situation changed → They changed. No analysis. Just action.



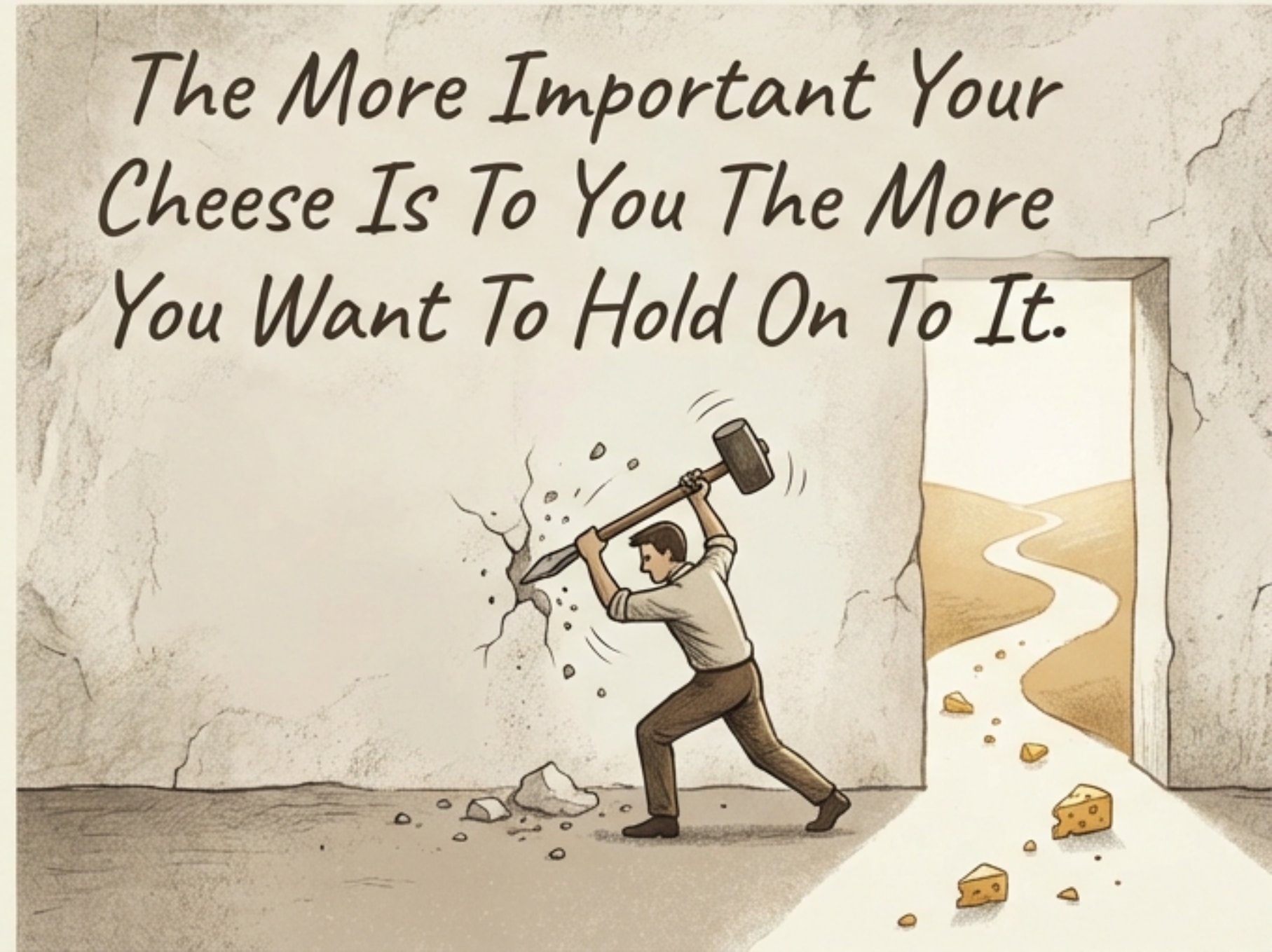
**Reaction:** Paralysis. Analysis, yelling, and shock. Hem screams: "Who moved my Cheese? It's not fair!"



# The Anatomy of Resistance

Why do we get stuck? Hem represents the part of us that refuses to accept the new reality.

- **The Entitlement Fallacy:** Believing we deserve the old rewards despite the new context.
- **Activity vs. Productivity:** Chiseling a hole in the wall is hard work, but it doesn't find new cheese.
- **Denial:** Ignoring the small signs (mold, diminishing supply) until the sudden crash.





# The Pivot Point

**The Awakening:** Haw finally laughs at himself. "We keep doing the same things over and over again and wonder why things don't get better."

**The Confrontation:** Shifting the question from "Who moved my Cheese?" to "Why didn't I move sooner?"



**The Decision:** Haw leaves the empty station. He realizes the fear in his mind is worse than the reality of the maze.

"Life moves on. And so should we."



**The Tool:** Visualization.

To overcome the paralyzing fear of the unknown, Haw painted a picture in his mind. He didn't visualize the struggle; he visualized the reward.

**The Principle:** When you stop being afraid, you feel good.





# The Handwriting on the Wall

*Change Happens: They keep moving the Cheese.*

*Anticipate Change: Get ready for the Cheese to move.*

*Monitor Change: Smell the Cheese often so you know when it is getting old.*

*Adapt Quickly: The quicker you let go of old cheese, the sooner you can enjoy new cheese.*

*Move with the Cheese.*

*Enjoy Change! Savor the adventure.*



# Arrival at Cheese Station N

**The Discovery:** The greatest supply of cheese Haw had ever seen.

**The Reunion:** The simple instincts (Sniff & Scurry) were already there because they treated the maze as a trial-and-error challenge, not a personal insult.





# Maintaining Agility

The lesson is not just to find cheese, but to be ready for it to move again.



- Inspect the supply every day (Monitor).
- Venture out into the maze occasionally (Anticipate).
- Keep your running shoes around your neck (Agility).



# The Mirror Test

Which part of you is running the show right now?



## SNIFF (Anticipator)

Are you sensing market trends before they hit?



Yes

No



## SCURRY (Executor)

Are you taking action immediately, or waiting for perfect data?



Yes

No



## HEM (Resister)

Are you waiting for the 'old cheese' (processes/roles) to return?



Yes

No



## HAW (Adapter)

Are you laughing at your fear and visualizing the new opportunity?

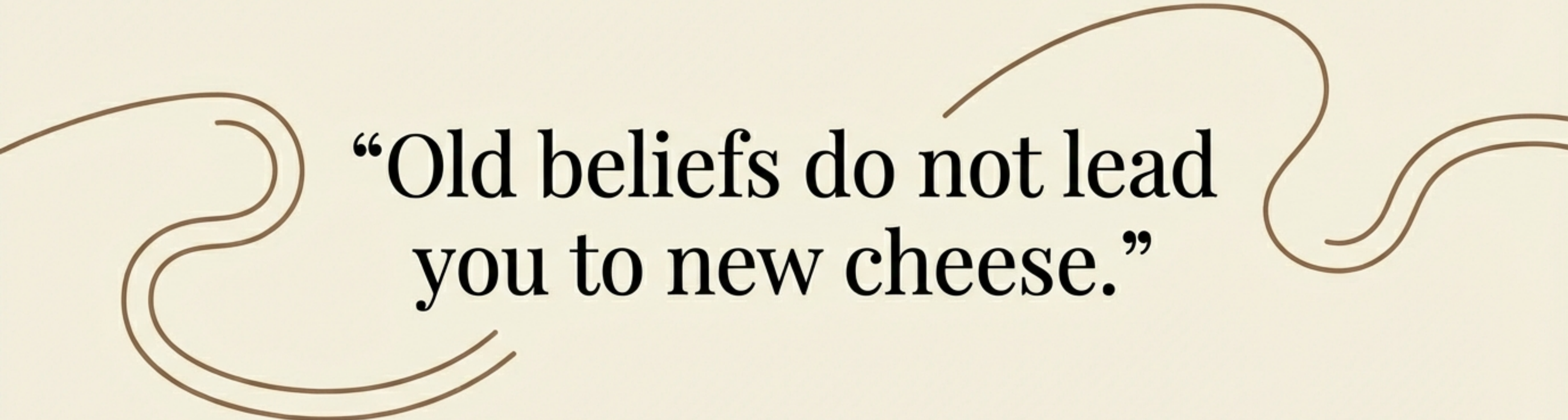


Yes

No



# Move With The Cheese



“Old beliefs do not lead  
you to new cheese.”

The Maze is not a place to fear. It is the only place where New Cheese exists.